those which came up in other areas associated with Ashoka. The greatest likelihood is therefore that, as before, Maski's community continued to believe in the deities that had traditionally protected them in life and death. The emperor's strange message was read, heard, and ignored.

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The great man's wishes were engraved into only one area of the Maski locality; in other places there seems a greater anxiety to ensure dissemination, for the same message is inscribed at more than one place within the same locality. The Chitradurga cluster of Ashokan epigraphs at Brahmagiri, Siddapura, and Jatinga-Rameshwara is a dramatic instance of this anxiety. Many stunning rocky landscapes can be encountered across large tracts in this part of Karnataka, so an abundance of locations was available. But these three epigraphs, instead of being spread out, are within a radius of five km. Siddapura was a little over a kilometre west of Brahmagiri while Jatinga-Rameshwara was less than five km north-west of it. These spots seem interlinked because of intervisibility. Siddapura looked towards Brahmagiri. From Brahmagiri, Siddapura and Jatinga-Rameshwara were both visible. From the panoramic hilltop of Jatinga-Rameshwara, in turn, these rocky locations in the neighbourhood where the emperor's message was inscribed could be seen. It is entirely possible that the combination of locational visibility and a more or less identical royal epigraph at all three locations ensured that they came to be seen as interconnected.

Let us look at these landscapes a little more closely. Brahmagiri is the name of a hill of granitic outcrops where, close to the base alignment that looks towards the Jatinga-Rameshwara hill, lies the boulder where a composite message combining the two early edicts of Ashoka was set down. The message had been sent here from Suvarnagiri, the provincial capital. Suvarnagiri was the base of a prince whose name we do not know